She would have loved you too

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28484043.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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Part 6 of Wants, Needs, Help, and a whole lot of trouble.

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by Skyinou

Summary

A few days after Prime's defeat. Catra and Glimmer need to talk about Angella. Catra expects the queen to still be kind, for the better or worse, but as usual the conversation takes a turn in a direction she didn't see coming.

"If I had been in your place, don’t you think I would have burnt the world too? I was so lucky to have my mom, and I didn’t realise it, and I dared blame you for being raised in a bad way."

Notes

Because everyone deserves loving parents.

All my She-Ra works are part of the same big story, check my main series' description for more informations!

See the end of the work for more notes

Angella

The two girls walk slowly up the stairs leading to the Moonstone. Glimmer could have teleported them both right there, but for now, she follows in Catra's steps. They have not shared a word since Catra asked the queen for a moment to talk. She knows, what Catra wants to talk about, and she also knows she shouldn't speak first. She has been waiting a long time, for her now-friend to be ready to talk about it. She won't suddenly press her with accusing questions.

They both sit down against a wall, next to each other, facing the Stone. Its light makes the dark night pleasantly bright, to Glimmer. Catra thinks its uncomfortable. There is no place to hide, no dark corner up there. That's why she chose that place, it feels like she can't back away. And also because the nostalgic atmosphere will prevent the queen to be overly nice.

One part of Catra hopes that her friend will lash out at her, get angry, hit her, hate her, leave her. That would be easier, she is accustomed to those feelings. But the other part of her is crying, begging for forgiveness, pleading for the warmth that the simple word *friend* means to her now. She feels so vulnerable, and she clings to the hope that the words Perfuma once gave her were right, that she didn't become weak and useless by opening her heart.

Catra holds both her knees as tight as she can to her chest. She drops her head on them and glances at Sparkles, who is doing the same, staring vaguely at the Moonstone. She knows she needs to start speaking, but the words are stuck in her throat. She can almost hear the word withhold by Sparkles' mouth 'Why?', even though the queen has no intention to let it out.

Catra knows Sparkles well enough, but right now, the question would help. Or maybe it wouldn't, maybe speaking first is the only way for her to not hide behind her walls, behind defensive words

and lies. She told herself she was ready, and it seemed so easy back when she started climbing up those stairs.

“I’m sorry, I have no idea how to talk about it… her…” She finally admits in a whispering voice.

“Would it be easier if you knew her?” Glimmer’s question makes Catra shudder. The only things she knows is the distorted tales from the Horde, and some rare words Adora blurts out sometimes before obviously forcing herself to shut her mouth, and that she was a very nice person who loved Glimmer and that Glimmer loved back.

“That would make me feel even more miserable, wouldn’t it?” Catra can’t help a little scoff in her voice.

“She was the best mom ever.” Glimmer starts anyway, trying her best to ignore Catra shivering next to her. A big kind part of her just wants to stop and hug her friend, but she knows it wouldn’t help, yet. “She was kind, just, fair, even if I always thought she was too strict with me when I was little. She could fly, so with my power we had a lot of fun, like dancing in the air, and dad would use his magic to make it more exciting too. I took my love for adventure from him, and got grounded sooooo many times without him around.”

“Grounded?” Catra honestly asks, her face hidden, nested against her knees. She had never heard that word be used in that context in the Fright Zone.

Glimmer looks at her, incredulous, and blinks a few times. “Seriously? What happened when you did something you weren’t supposed to?”

“Not allowed to sleep for a few days? No food for a week? Tortures?” Catra raises her head briefly to glare at the princess.

Glimmer looks horrified at how Catra said it so naturally. “I- didn’t know it was that bad, Adora rarely mention-”

“Why would she? She was always on the good side. Except for me, she was following most of the rules. And then Shado… Shadow Weaver would punish me double time for both of us.” Catra pauses, the name turning her mouth dry.

“I’m sorry to hear-”

“Just, shut up and tell your stupid story.” She knows she doesn’t mean the *stupid* part, and the princess not taking offence both annoys and soothes her.

“That doesn’t make sense.” Glimmer chuckles, but resumes once she sees Catra looking at her with pleading eyes. “Right. Grounded. When I was bad, she would send me to my room and I wasn’t allowed to get out for a time, or was stuck inside the castle for a week or two. The day we met Adora was one of those. Bow suddenly came to get me for some adventure, a big First Ones tech discovery or something, and I knew mom would forgive me if I came back with it. I was never good at following rules either.”

“Yeah, right, rebel princess-”

“Catra! Do you think we are that different? We’re both stubborn, defiant and way quicker to lie than we want. But as much as we wish we could, we are unable to hide our emotions. We are snarky, impatient, strong, rash, loving the thrill of adventure and whatever makes us feel alive, but we are also easily lonely, and most of all wanting to be acknowledged. Even the way we fight is similar, both jumping around everywhere! The only difference was her! And you don’t understand how guilty I feel about it.”

“What guilt could *you* have? I’m the one who killed her! Why would it matter if we are the same?!”

“She loved me! I know she would have loved you too! If she had found you instead of Shadow Weaver, we could have been raised as sisters! If I had been in your place, don’t you think I would have burnt the world too? I was so lucky to have my mom, and I didn’t realise it, and I dared blame *you* for being raised so bad.”

“You can’t blame Shadow Weaver for everything I did!”

“Of course not, but in the few days I spent with her, she made me doubt my friends and nearly destroy the universe! I have to tell myself everyday that Prime would have gotten here on his own anyway, in order to forgive myself. Then she drove you away and we were so close to lose Adora too-”

“Wait wait, what did you do?”

Glimmer gasps at the interruption. “You don’t know?”

Catra shakes her head.

“I’m the one responsible for getting Etheria out in the universe, when Adora and Bow were assuring me that it was a bad idea. I didn’t listen, I left them. You have no idea how right you were when you said we were both alone, when I found you in the Fright Zone.”

“But you are right, Prime would have found Etheria out eventually. His technology was way ahead of the First Ones’ after all. And I…”

“And you are the one who told him were to look, right. And Entrapta was the one who made the portal, and we were the ones who abandoned her, and you see we can play the Shift the Blame Game all day!”

“Then how does that *game* end?”

“I’m trying to make you look where it starts for you. Shadow Weaver might not be responsible for all you did, but she is for how you thought, for how wrong you were. When I saw you ready to die, after you even defeated Hordak, I knew Double Trouble was right. The real you was hidden, scared, alone, somewhere behind all that crap she put in your head.”

Catra raises her head with curiosity. Then sighs. “Of course, they didn’t escape and come to take me down on their own. That was low by the way, for a princess.”

"I know. And you know whose idea it was. I thought it was only fair. Until we ended up on Prime's ship. I wanted to use you to get out, at first. But you came to see me again and again, and I told you, we are way more similar than any of us two wants to believe, so it didn't take long before I saw myself as being the lucky one again. I was scared, hoping my friends would come and save me. You didn't even have that hope."

"That was my fault. I chased everyone away." Catra's ears flatten.

"Yeah, and you started to talk to me about Adora. The one little thing linking us. So fond of her, nostalgic of a lost time. So I threw my pity and blame away and started to want to know you too, to understand you. Because that's who I am, because that's how my mom taught me to be."

"Urgh, do you have to make it so dramatic? Unlike you, I only thought I was on the right side of the wall."

"And then you saved me, how's that for *dramatic*?"

"I wanted to save Adora, not you." Catra's ears twitch at the uncomfortable correction.

"Keep telling yourself that."

"You don't believe me?" Catra blinks a few times in surprise.

"Not even a little."

"Why? I believe it."

"Catra, rushing with the first plan we have, risking our lives for others, is something we, princesses, do. You were commander of the Horde, mastermind behind every of its successes, if you didn't want to save me, you would have thought of a better plan that at least had some chance of you getting out of it. You didn't even hurt me to make sure we would hate you and not come back."

"You are thinking way too far into it, Sparkles."

“One of us has to use her brain!” She grins at Catra, who can’t help but scoff playfully. “We are here to talk about us, however deep we need to dig. Unfortunately, I don’t have claws, so I need words!”

“That was dumb!” Catra smiles shyly at Glimmer's weird attempt at humour in their situation, but it stupidly works anyway, she can feel herself relax a little.

“No, what was dumb was us trying to rescue you. But when Adora asked, I didn’t hesitate for a second. And I would do it again, because it was worth it. You were- are worth saving, Catra, even if you called us idiots for even trying.”

“How can you say that so confidently?” Catra hides her face between her knees again, feeling tears gathering at the corners of her eyes, the excess of emotions and kindness starting to get to her.

“I simply believe it. Special princess’ power! Another lucky gift I received from... her.” Glimmer tries to talk cheerfully, but at another mention of Angella, she begins to sob. “You are a good person Catra. You proved it. And there’s no way mom would disagree. So instead of wanting punishment for her loss, you have to continue to try hard, to make up for it. She wouldn’t want you gone either.”

“I hate you.” Catra sniffles, she hates her own words, she hates how she doesn’t know how to respond better, and the tears start to roll down her cheeks. She remembers again, nobody taught her how to accept kindness. Nor how to give it in return. But the princess does.

“You know, I would hug you if you only opened your heart a little more.” Glimmer is smiling behind her own tears, she doesn’t need more proper words to understand her friend.

Catra raises her head, tears pouring out, she feels like a little kid again and that hug seems like something she has always wanted.

“I never learnt how to do that!”

“It’s okay, I did.” Glimmer isn’t sure if she meant the hug or opening her heart but it doesn’t matter. She takes her in a tight embrace, and rests her head on top of Catra’s.

Catra jumps at the sudden gesture, but quickly the warmth and kindness overtake her. She turns and clings at Glimmer with both hands, and she lets herself cry loudly. It has been so long since she last allowed herself to. “I’m sorry!” She finally manages to say between two watery weeps.

“I know. I forgive you.” Glimmer answers, sobbing all the same.

The two girls continue crying for long minutes in the night, the Moonstone basking them in its warm light. They let out all the sadness, regrets and remorse as they cling to each other, as if Angella’s kind spirit was hugging them too.

When they finally calm down and loosen up their grips, Catra whispers. “*Sisters*, hu.” She smiles.

Glimmer clears her throat softly. “If you tell anyone I said that, I’ll make you regret it for the rest of your life!”

“Oh yeah? What could you even do to me now?” Catra’s snide is back in her voice, but her smile stays soft.

“I won’t tell that you asked me for a hug, deal?”

“Deal, Sparkles.”

“Now we should go back, there is a lot to prepare for tomorrow’s meeting. I could use some help.”

Catra chuckles a little. “Oh yeah, your guards’ training schedule is a mess,” She starts.

“I know.”

“And the management of supplies needs so much improvements,”

“I know!”

“And don’t get me started on how you princesses solve-”

“I know! So are you going to do something about it or not?”

“What?”

“Catra, do you want to officially work with me?”

“You mean work *for* you?” Catra, taken by surprise, doesn’t even have time to be really snarky.

“Same difference. I mean a real job, title, payment, schedule. Unless Adora and you plan on lazily spend your days, at the castle expenses, using the *we saved the world* excuse all your life?” Sparkles flashes a wide grin at Catra.

“Hey, we help a lot around. Won’t the other advisers be mad if the queen gives *me* a title? That would be odd?”

“Not like I ever was a textbook queen anyway! The rules I cross might seem trifling to *you*, but believe me, for Bright Moon’s standards, I’m quite an unruly leader.” Glimmer declaims, a hand on her chest theatrically. “Then, can you give me an answer by tomorrow’s meeting?”

“I’ll think about it.” Behind her drying tears and her smile, Catra blushes faintly.

“Good. Now can I get us down? I reeeeally don’t have the courage to take the stairs again!”

Catra has no time to answer that Sparkles grins, winks at her and teleports them both anyway. They appear in the corridor leading to both their rooms. Catra staggers, dizzy as usual after being the victim of Glimmer’s power. Two strong familiar arms catch her as she is about to fall against the wall and their blonde owner smiles

at her. Glimmer laughs as she lets herself drop dramatically in Bow's arms.

Their two lovers were waiting for them and after a few worried glances at the red eyes and teary cheeks, Bow and Adora both scoop up their smiling girlfriend, one arm under the knees, the other under the back, and carry them to their respective bedrooms after exchanging short goodnights.

By the time they arrive, Catra has buried her face in Adora's shoulder and she's clinging to her neck with both arms. Adora closes the door behind them with her foot and walks to the bed. She loosens her arms a little, but Catra doesn't move.

"Catra?" Without any kind of answer, Adora tries to sit down on the bed, stumbling slightly in the process.

Catra chuckles but stays otherwise silent. Adora nuzzles her big ears, and starts combing her short hair slowly. Melog jumps from behind the bed where they were sleeping and rests their head against Catra's chest. It takes a few moments for her to relax, then she begins to purr slightly.

"How did it go?" Adora asks in a whispering voice.

"Well, she didn't throw me off the tower. She could have, I did that to Bow once." Catra laughs nervously.

"It's okay. I'm sure she-"

"I'm okay, Adora! I just needed your warmth to recharge for a bit." Catra finally raises her head, smiling.

"Recharge? Weren't we going straight to sleep anyway?" Adora winces at the probably not-intended innuendo.

"I wish. But right now, we need to talk. About Shadow Weaver."

"We do? You… want to?"

“Yes, there are so many things we didn’t tell each other because of her. I need to let all that out or I feel I’ll regret it. Since Sparkles made me all soft and teary already, might as well grab that opportunity.”

Shadow

Chapter Summary

> After talking with Sparkles, Catra decides that talking with Adora about Shadow Weaver will help, and she won't shut up until her princess realises that she has serious issues too.

“How are we doing this?” Adora doesn’t mind sitting with Catra in her arms, that would be the understatement of the year, but it doesn’t seem to be the best way to have a proper, probably long and serious discussion.

Catra leaves her embrace and lies down on one side of the bed. She invites Melog to jump in the middle and points a finger at the empty side, where Adora flops down facing her. They look at each other for a moment, only separated by a big magical cat, then Catra extends a hand. Melog recoils back a little to the foot of the bed to let free space between the two girls’ head so they can interact somewhat without bothering the big cat. Adora holds Catra’s hand and gives her a questioning look. Not that she doesn’t appreciate the contact.

“So you don’t let me run away. And I won’t let you either.” Catra says glancing at their hands.

“I have no reason to?” Adora replies even more perplexed.

“I’m probably going to hurt you.” Catra’s words startle Adora who instinctively pulls back the slightest distance and Catra strengthens the hold on her hand. “See? I don’t want to hurt you but if we are going to talk about our past, you know it will not be all... gentle.”

Adora gives her another puzzled look but nod in acknowledgment.

“Maybe I’m wrong, but I think you don’t realise where this is going to go…” Catra continues.

"You know I'm here for you, whatever happens, whatever happened."

"That's exactly what I'm talking about! You believe it's all about me, but we are *both* broken."

"Tell me then." Adora retorts, slightly offended yet curious.

Catra takes a deep breath to not let Adora's obliviousness ruin her determination. "Do you remember when we first entered the Garnet's chamber as kids?" That memory still haunts Catra because it destroyed her life twice. Once when it happened, then another time when the First Ones tech made her relive it and she turned against Adora partly because of that.

"Yeah, Shadow Weaver was so mad." Adora chortles.

Usually the sound warms Catra's heart but right now she feels cold and she can't ignore Melog's mane changing into a pale blue. Only her hand is safe and enveloped in Adora's warmth. "She never used her power directly on you didn't she?"

Adora shivers. "No. Not like that. She tried to make me go crazy once in Mystacor but-"

"Please imagine what it's like to be unable to move, unable to breathe, while her voice rings in your head as she tells you that you are nothing, you are a parasite leeching off good little girl Adora. Always threatening to dispose of me if I dragged you away from the bright future she had for you."

"It's over now, *I* won't let it happen again."

"But I'm reminded again and again when you act like that!"

"Like what?"

"Ugh." Catra sighs and breathes deeply again before resuming her story. "What do you think happened some days later when she found us on another little adventure in the skiff hangar?"

“The same thing, more or less, if I remember correctly?”

“Yeah. Mostly. And you? She barely scolded you.”

“Hey, we know she was quite biased about me now-”

“But as it kept happening again and again, somewhere inside my heart I started to hope for you to get hurt too, until-” Catra tightens her hold on Adora’s faintly retracting hand again.

That’s what Catra fears the most right now. Those bad childhood memories don’t hurt her as much as the recent ones she has to make amends for; she had time to analyse them, understand them and because of her earlier talk with Sparkles her mind is clearer. But opening her eyes about them will hurt Adora badly, and that kind of pain will make Adora feel extremely guilty for not having done more to prevent those memories from happening. And a guilty Adora can leave faster than an abandoned Catra, who needs the blonde girl to stay long enough to understand that this is part of the problem.

The only reason the feline girl put a Melog’s size distance between them instead of hugging her princess in place is because the talk with Sparkles convinced her that they have to talk about it, and if she was comfy in Adora’s arms, she wouldn’t speak. She would delude herself again that she can simply forget about everything, but she knows better now. They need that talk to be able to go forward with their life and their relationship.

“Until what?” Adora asks impatiently.

“I understood that you were never gonna be punished, and I was never going to be anything else than a pest and a shadow!”

“But it wasn’t so bad-”

“I was a little kid, Adora! She threatened to kill me, used her magic to keep me from breathing, played with my body like a puppet long before we were cadets! Long before the war’s dangers and deaths became our everyday lives! I was terrified!

And the only thing that kept me going was your promise to stay with me! Because despite resenting you for having it easy, I needed you. I.. *wanted* you. I had only you…"

Adora recoils a little when she realises once more that Catra's only anchor was her and her promise, and she… But Catra quickly tightens the hold of her hand and goes on.

"Everyday became a struggle to be close to you and follow you, and being punished for it, yet the only comfort I had was being with you and the circle started all over again. And you had no idea, and you dragged me to do things that would get me punished for because they were fun, and I needed it. And soon I was acting tough like that was no big deal anymore and disobeying on my own. But the damage was done; as much as I liked you, those embers of hate she planted were not going to vanish anytime soon."

"You could have told me about it!"

"How? She had already made sure I was feeling like I deserved it. She *made* me undisciplined and defiant. Acting like that was the only bit of freedom I had left, breaking rules was the only way for me to feel alive. She let me no choice, so everybody would side with her against an *unruly nuisance* like me."

"You know I wouldn't have."

"I wasn't sure back then, you were always on her good side. I endured, I doubted, I *did* spend nights wondering if I should tell you, cry in front of you to show how hurt I was. And when I was about to crack, she would make sure I remembered how pathetic I would look if I did, and how *you* would probably hate me for it!"

"She was lying-"

"Of course she was! She manipulated us all our lives! Like she made you believe that your attempts at protecting me were ever successful!"

“What was I suppose to do, watch and do nothing?”

“How do you think I felt seeing you always acting like I needed to be protected yet never involving yourself enough to get punished? I felt weak, and second even to her!”

“I was honestly trying!”

“But you failed! I didn’t want your help in the first place, I wasn’t that weak, I could endure it, I *did* endure it! If at least you had succeeded or pushed past her I would have felt safe. Weak, useless, but safe! The only time you managed to protect *me* before it was too late was at the Heart of Etheria, *after* I had to save *you*! But no, you still try to play the hero around me, trying to protect me, looking so guilty for everything that happens to me, like I want She-Ra instead of you!”

Catra takes a little breather but resumes before Adora can speak up once more.

“I only needed you. Not your protection, not your help, not your worry, just you. And then you left me and everything went wrong... I acted exactly like the person she grew me into, I tried to please her instead of joining you, I thought I finally had a chance to become first, since you weren’t there anymore. I even beat her to prove how strong I was. In vain. And when she finally asked for a favour from the depth of her cell, I eagerly grabbed the chance regardless... but she was only using me again to get back to you! And I broke down… It’s so obvious now, but I couldn’t see then, how much she did to us on purpose.”

“Catra, you’re okay now, she can’t do-”

“Only you mattered! It hurt! She made me so aware of it that I almost destroyed everything! And she made you so aware of it that you still can’t help it! It would be so much easier if you weren’t so strong…” Catra sighs as her expression sours in a sad smile.

“You want me to be weak?!”

"You wouldn't believe so much that it's your *job* to protect people, to protect me! That way I would see that you stick around because you love me, not because you are afraid to fail, if something happens to me."

"But I take it as my *job* to not let anything happen to you *because* I love you!"

"I know! But the way you go about it is so infuriating, so *her*, placing duties above everything else! Unable to relax, unable to stop to look at me until the *job* is done! I don't want you to constantly *go on the mission to protect me*, I want you to *stay with me* so it just happens that you are here when we need to protect each other."

"Oh." Adora remarks. Catra may have a point there and she doesn't know where the conversation is going anymore.

"See, *that's* what I wanted to talk about. She may have tortured me but the memories of it are the least of our concerns now that it's over! She ruined us so much deeper than that. She has still so much power over us both and you don't realise. But at least *my* issues are sharp enough that I'm aware of them." Then Catra mumbles. "Also because Sparkles and you won't shut up about my problems…"

"I'm so sorry-"

"Please don't-" Catra interrupts.

"No, I truly am, I mean, you are right." Adora resumes, shushing Catra back. "I didn't think even half as much as you did about it. I was only prepared to listen to you and hug you as much as you needed, reassure you, accept any blame you wanted me to bear. I should have thought-"

"Adora, if you had thought any more about this you would have stressed out and imagine even stupider things and spiralled down out of control again because of her. That's part of the problem too."

‘I’m not that bad-’ Adora stops herself for voicing out the first thing that comes to her mind. Catra is looking at her tenderly and opening up so earnestly that her heart hesitates. “Am I that bad?”

“Yes you are. Of course everyone appreciates how kind and always ready to help you are, me included, but you being always restless, reckless and borderline suicidal for it comes from all that crap she put in your head.”

“Okay. No. I’m definitely not that bad.”

“Rescuing me, the blockade, the Failsafe, the Heart? You wanting to play the hero so much that you feel guilty when you can’t? And you are unable to calm down! Even earlier you were all jittery until I managed to smile.”

“I know I have trouble relaxing but-”

“You can’t even relax in your sleep! Stars we even bonded over that with Sparkles on Prime’s ship because it is so *you*! But during the war that was acceptable with everything going on, even cute,” Catra blinks slowly. “but now we have finally peace, and each other, if you still can’t relax at least when you are awake, then admit you really have a problem!”

“Oh.” Adora remarks again without being able to form a proper argument.

“Every time you make Sparkles frown during a meeting because you accept one more task than needed, every time you use that task as an excuse, every time you feel the pressure crushing you but you stubbornly stays alone, every time you think that duty is worth your life, that you are guilty for everything bad that happens in the world, it’s *her* acting through you! You understand why I said you are as broken as me now?”

“I can’t simply switch my worries off! It’s normal to be a little antsy when you have so many responsibilities! I can’t help it if I want to help everyone-”

“She made you crave to protect and feel guilty for the whole universe because she needed you to be ready to give your life. And I hated that part of you because you believed you were protecting me, when she was only using that to condition you and create a rift between us, so I would push you away and you would choose your duty instead of me in the end. I learnt earlier today her full story with Micah and it’s making so much fricking sense that she tried earlier and stronger with you like that!”

“Catra, I-”

“I know but it still hurts! And it shouldn’t because it’s all over. But she’s still in your head, pushing you away from me with misplaced guilt and responsibilities. She made all of this. The only thing she didn’t plan for us was you recognising the evil the Horde was doing so clearly that you ran away. If I could go back to that time I would laugh so hard at her failure when it happens! And then *I* would leave too, and maybe then we could be free…” Catra sniffles, a tear threatening to drop from her eye.

“Please stop-”

“You agreed to talk, I’m not letting you out of-”

“No! I mean I get it! If it’s so bad that you are crying for me, I get it! And even if you don’t want to hear it, I’m sorry, for being oblivious and stubborn and *an idiot*. You are amazing, Catra, you thought so much about this, I didn’t even-”

“Because I’m fucking scared!!” Catra shouts. “If you want to help everyone, fine, but do it because you like it, not because she made you feel like you have to! Your guilt and hero complex are ruining you, and I won’t be able to take it if they destroy our relationship any more! I’m betting everything on Sparkles’ words that talking is the way out!” She takes a deep breath to calm down. “When you fuss over me to protect me or feel sorry with that look on your face like you are crushed by the weight of the world, it hurts so much...”

“But I’ve no idea what to do... how am I supposed to get better from that?” Adora starts to look very anxious.

“Take me away on a deserted planet with only us, far from everything?” Catra jokes and sheepishly grins with watery eyes.

“Yeah, right.” Adora chuckles and her face softens. “But seriously?”

“Forget your stupid duties now and then, ask people for help to get some free time yourself, and when you really have to accept another extra mission to help someone, smile and say *I’ll be back soon!* instead of looking devastated saying *I’m sorry*. I’ll be lonely but at least I’ll feel like you are trying. And if you manage to finish early and rush to me to spend that little bit of time together, that would be nice. But I can’t get better if you don’t. *I* still need you.” Catra’s tear finally rolls down her cheek and she sniffles again.

“How is that enough?”

“It isn’t, but it’s a start. I want a girlfriend, not a guardian. I want to see you happy. And I want your attention, your time, all of it. I want your smile, not your creepy guilty look or worried one... I have no idea how to fix this... Maybe go talk to Perfuma or something? ... Now it’s your turn to talk.” Catra coughs quietly.

“Are you okay?!”

“Yes…” Catra sighs and growls at Adora’s overreaction.

“Sorry…”

“You really need help!” Catra coughs again and Adora does her best to smile and put her worries aside. Then Catra whispers to spare her throat. “I’ll get even with Sparkles later for making me talk so much!” Both girls chuckle.

“I bet you will. But she was right, we… I needed it.”

“Hey, it was my idea! I simply took advices and examples from her!” Catra smugly replies.

“But you know, growing up wasn’t all bad.” Adora decides to switch to a somewhat lighter talk for now. “We had some happy moments too, right? I was always eager to learn and you were following me everywhere. Before I knew it you were so much smarter and resourceful than most. At the beginning I was proud of you- I guess I was misguided by Shadow Weaver in thinking that you were my responsibility? But then I started to feel warm and proud to simply be your friend instead. I thought we were equals and that you really wanted to stay behind me all the time; I wish I had seen sooner that you didn’t actually like being my shadow. We could have had more fun in there.”

“Yeah. Even with… Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio. I can’t believe I miss them. *Me.* After what I-”

“Don’t. One problem at a time.”

Catra nods.

“Then I guess we need to talk about her death.” Adora starts to speak very seriously this time. “I think she was messed up but since she’s dead and voluntarily or not helped us at last, I told myself I was just going to try and forget her. But you cried for her too and after all that talk it doesn’t really make any sense to me?”

“I was so sure I was out of her grasp when we came back from space. Then she appears, takes you away from me again and when I finally think I don’t care what could happen to her, she dies for me and says *I’m proud of you!* Of *me*!” Catra takes a deep breath and suddenly yells. “I DON’T CARE! I’m not supposed to care! … why do I care, Adora?! Why…” And she starts crying.

Adora jumps at Catra’s loudness and tightens her hold on her hand. She knows she can’t answer that question properly yet. She bridges the gap between them and embraces Catra, shoving

Melog aside in the process. The magical cat shrinks and meows unhappily and the princess invites them to hug Catra too.

"Adora, stop-"

"Don't ask me to watch you cry like that without doing anything, that's not fair! I promise I'll reflect on what you said but it's enough for now. It hurts a lot to see you cry too." Adora replies as she curls around Catra.

Catra can't keep her composure anymore and melts into Adora's arms and allow herself to cry again freely like she did earlier with Sparkles. It's unfair how safe she feels there, when she tried to convince Adora a moment ago to not act too protective, or maybe it's because of it that any more protection from Adora feels so excessive and irritating. Melog jumps over her to join the hug, nuzzles her head and purrs loudly, soothing as always.

"Remember…" Adora starts to recall some more happy memories. They do have some. Enough to spend a whole night talking about at least and Catra slowly recovers. Her pain and doubts aren't erased but she knows she can move forward with her life and her love for now. Adora promised to think about her own problems too. It's a start, and they have time now. When they finally go to sleep the sun is already out. They are exhausted but they feel lighter, more free, and they are smiling, warm in each other's arms.

Broken

Chapter Summary

> "Adora?! What are you doing here?" Glimmer shouts when she finds her friend sitting against the wall.
>
> "I…" Adora barely lifts her head to look at Glimmer, lost in her thoughts and apparently very anxious. "Can we… talk?"

"Adora?! What are you doing here?" Glimmer shouts when she finds her friend sitting against the wall, just outside the meeting room she was cleaning up after a long discussion with her advisers about giving a real, recognised job to Catra. It took her a lot of effort to make them accept this and another lot of it to simply stay calm at their stubborn protests.

"I…" Adora barely lifts her head to look at Glimmer, lost in her thoughts and apparently very anxious. "Can we… talk?"

The queen flinches. Her friend acting like this is very unusual, except for the anxious part, sadly, and since yesterday she had that talk with Catra about her mother, she begins to wonder if she said something she shouldn't have. Glimmer had been prepared for that talk since she had offered it to Catra, a few days after her rescue, she had thought about it, considered what should better help, how best to avoid further damage to both of them.

But Catra grew up in the Fright Zone, raised by Shadow Weaver, so different, so foreign that the queen's words might not have been *appropriate*. Catra seemed better and relieved at the end but maybe Adora is here now all depressed because it backfired and wants to tell Glimmer off, with no idea how without straining their friendship.

"Sure." Not wanting to continue blindly guessing standing in a hallway, Glimmer grabs Adora and teleports both of them to her room. Adora flops on a giant cushion and almost drowns in it

completely limp, which seriously worries her friend once more. "Adora, what's wrong?"

Adora seems to curl in a ball and whine, her face hidden in the fluffy fabric as Glimmer sits beside her. "I… we… Am I broken?"

"Of course not! What are you saying? We won, and you even got She-Ra back for good." Glimmer's previous doubts vanish but only to be replaced by another layer of uneasiness.

Adora sits up straight and she smiles wryly. "Right. What am I saying, of course I'm okay, everything is fine!" She is about to stand up when Glimmer stops her. Adora doubting herself is like her second nature and shouldn't worry Glimmer more than usual but *this*, this doesn't sound like doubt, this sounds like Adora being already convinced, yet unconsciously trying to talk with her friend about it because she has no idea how to deal with this.

"That's not what you wanted to hear, is it?"

Adora instantly deflates and drops back in her cushion again, her mind visibly storming for a moment in silence, filled with that pretend doubt her friend pointed out on purpose, and she knows Glimmer wouldn't do this to be mean. She couldn't even lie to herself long enough to stand up and leave the room, showing her troubles so apparently that Glimmer called her on it. She sighs in acceptance and the word echoes in her head again with an added weight. *Broken*. She exhales slowly. "Shit..." Adora whispers, gritting her teeth.

"Why do you think you are broken?"

"Catra told me."

"What?! How could she… I'm sure she didn't mean it, Adora! Don't worry about it."

"She meant it and I think she's right..."

“You can’t be serious?! After all that happened you are finally free to do whatever you want, live however you want. You saved the universe, I don’t think someone broken can do that, even if you needed a little help. You even got Catra back… she isn’t thinking about leaving, is she?!”

“No! No. But she thinks Shadow Weaver messed with me too much...”

“You are great Adora. You are strong and a good leader! The rebellion would have achieved nothing without you, even without She-Ra you are a good strategist and a capable soldier.”

“But I-”

“No buts! You are a good friend, you are kind, brave, always ready to help, and even funny, sometimes!” Glimmer smiles as she tries to end her argument on a light note.

“When you deny it so strongly I want to believe you but I can’t, I just- I can’t-” Adora suddenly speeds up and stumbles on her words. “I won’t choose… I can’t- I still believe Catra and-”

“Okay, slow down and give me more details. We are getting nowhere like this. What did she say exactly?”

“Yesterday we talked about our past. It was good but Catra believes that the way Shadow Weaver raised us, and the Horde, and the Fright Zone, let us with... deep issues.” Adora’s voice turns to barely more than a whisper, ashamed of what she admits. “Like me never relaxing, wanting to protect people without regards for my own life, being always guilty, always sorry, always anxious, always… I don’t know...”

“Hurrh… being stuck in semantics after that long *rhetoric* meeting is giving me a headache! Adora, I would never say *broken*, maybe *misguided*? *Troubled*? But that’s me, Catra obviously uses different words… please start with that next time!”

“Regardless of the word, you aren’t denying it then… You didn’t force me to face that?”

“First, I don’t think it helps to throw that to your face. Second, *you* don’t really respond well when we suggest you need help?”

Adora tries to deny but stumbles again and hesitates, and the words don’t even reach her mouth that Glimmer carries on instead.

“You were always curious so little things like teaching you about the *real* world were fine but you strongly believe that you have to do everything important on your own and that accepting help is out of the question, let alone asking for it. Even when you lost She-Ra you couldn’t stop! We did a lot as a team with the Best Friend Squad and the Princess Alliance, but at the end of the day, when it really counts, you always take most of the burden to carry on *your* shoulders only.”

“Yeah, that’s part of me being *broken*, according to Catra. With me fussing, worrying endlessly, feeling guilty for the world and never relaxing…”

“Well, yes, obviously...”

Adora sighs and sinks a little further into her cushion. “You both say it’s *obvious*. It’s not for me!” There is a glint of frustration in Adora’s voice but it’s so far buried under everything else that she only sounds desperate and impossibly sad.

“I see. Me and Bow, and the others, have been at your side, ready to help, even against your will if needed, from the beginning. You came from the Horde, there was always some sort of expectation that you had deep scars from it. But we respect that, we don’t want to intrude too far. Now that the war is over you have all the time you need to heal.”

“So you really think it’s that serious too…” Adora sighs again and grips her own arms.

“Of course it’s serious, you almost died, Adora! And I’m not talking only about the Heart of Etheria. We never hid that we thought you were always doing too much and pointlessly blaming yourself for everything bad happening. We have to force you to even take breaks, breathe a little and have some fun, take your mind away from your negativity. But there was a reason for you to fight it before, there was a real threat, not anymore... I thought you were at least aware of it?”

“I don’t know. I thought I was. But… but when Catra told me it suddenly felt so… real.”

“If it’s so hard for you to accept, I guess Catra may have been right to drop the gloves, but you shouldn’t suddenly try to rush things now that we finally have peace. Once the rebuilding effort slows down-”

“She said that me being broken like this was hurting her! I don’t know what to do but I can’t not do anything either!”

“I believe you will slowly get better as you let go and forget the past but I’m not Catra, I didn’t think this would hurt her so much, enough to spell it out to you, enough to shake you like that. She is kind of amazing actually. I wouldn’t say I never tried...”

“I can’t get what happened with the Failsafe out of my head. I thought she was being selfish, wanting me safe over the chance to save everyone else, but I’m the selfish one, aren’t I? I couldn’t even look her in the eyes and say how important she was to me, all the while asking her to watch me sacrifice myself.” Adora gasps and exhales heavily as if it is painful to even breathe and curls a little more on herself. “I’m scared, Glimmer. Scared to be blind to my own issues, scared that *slowly getting better* isn’t good enough to make Catra happy.”

“It’s okay to be afraid, sometimes. Maybe use it to get over yourself and ask for help? I mean really reaching, not barely accepting people walking alongside you? I always thought we were equals but you know how you often don’t make me feel that

way. Well, except for a few times like right now I mean. If I have to guess, you did the same to Catra, always a step ahead of her, always one hand in front of her to protect."

Adora flinches. "It hurts when you see it so simply-"

"I had a lot of practice and a lot of time to think, in a cell, if you recall, and I thought about you and Bow, and the others, but Catra was there too. I wanted to understand how she ended up that bad." Glimmer smiles at Adora and puts a hand on her shoulder before the blonde girl can dig any deeper in that direction. "But we are getting off track. My point is, there are a lot of people that you barely let follow you instead of slowing down to accept their help, and it's not too late to turn around and ask them."

"You want me to be a burden to a lot of people just to try to feel better myself?" Adora can't help but find the idea outrageous even if it makes sense.

"Helping a friend is not a burden! Of course you don't want to be whining all the time on their shoulders but you are so far from that! Try to compromise a little? When you keep your worries to yourself all day long and they pile up, it's these same people who have to see you crushed by their weight anyway! Remember, people close to you are sharing your pain, whether you willingly talk about your problems or not!"

"If only I was able to hide-"

Glimmer growls. "You can't do that, and I don't mean only *you* you, people who love you will always see through that kind of things one day or another! Even if you have Hordak's stuck up face!" She grins.

Adora chuckles a little. "And *I can't act to save my life*..."

"Exactly. And even with my *overwhelming hubris* I can tell you simply: you only have two choices. Let time slowly heal you while we leave the past behind or force yourself to change; you know,

as you said, accept help, stop fussing over everything, slow down your impulse to worry over or save everyone...”

“You mean, feeling like shit doing *nothing*, to not strain myself any more than I do on my own already, or forcefully trying to accept other values while feeling like I’m letting everyone down… nice choices.” Adora chuckles again but so ironically that her smile almost seems evil.

“Nobody said it was easy.” Glimmer frowns and straightens up, enough to look even more menacing as she glares down at Adora and her hand presses a little more on the blonde girl’s shoulder. “If you can’t see the better choice, you need to do the only thing you can’t afford not to do.”

“Which is?” Adora recoils with the feeling that competing over *looking imposing* is pointless in her state.

“If you decide to force yourself to change, it will be difficult, it will be tiring and frightening. You will have to question and doubt yourself again and again. You will feel weak and helpless, and I know that means a lot to you. Think of it as reliving your childhood while being painfully aware of what’s really happening this time but still not being able to change the facts, only what you learn from them.”

“Okay, no. How can I choose that?!”

“You said it yourself, if you don’t, you will hurt Catra, maybe lose her for good.”

“Oh.”

“First, you need to talk to my and Bow’s dads.” Glimmer continues as if the choice is so obvious that she doesn’t need Adora to confirm it. “You never had proper parents. They can explain things that you lacked growing up from another perspective. You need to go see Perfuma regularly; every day would be good. I know what you think of her meditation but it’s exactly why you need to try again. It’s all in your head and if your mind is now convinced you

need to do something about this, it should help- it *will* help. Spinnerella and Netossa will gladly share their own experiences too when you need advice about your relationship with Catra. And obviously Bow and I will be there every time you need us. I'll force you to work less, breathe and take full breaks, giving you time to work on your issues, pointing them out more often, that sort of things."

"I'm... not confident I can do all that?" Despite her words Adora is looking significantly better now and the tone of her voice is lighter.

"Adora, Catra is smart. Smarter than me, smarter than you. If she decided to confront you about this, I'm sure she believes you can do it. So I'm going to believe her too."

"Believe her? You don't really think it's the right thing to do?"

"It's... not my place to decide, Adora. I don't think… I won't impose my ideas on you-" Glimmer flinches but does her best to hide it. She almost added *anymore* but now is not the time to give another reason for Adora to worry. "You said it too, you chose Catra, and it's a good thing! And I'll always support you two."

"Okay, but you are still my best friend and-"

"It's not a competition!"

"I… thanks! I mean it. Thank you." Adora finally manages to smile convincingly for the first time since the conversation started.

"You should go see her now. I'm sure she's waiting for you." Glimmer winks. She knows their schedules and she can't imagine that Adora told Catra much about why she would come back late. "We'll arrange the details for you at tomorrow's morning meeting."

They hug for a long time after that. Then Adora stands up, staggering, she still looks anxious but her eyes are resolved, filled with determination, not resignation.

Long after Adora left, Glimmer is still sitting on her cushion hugging her knees. Without the comfort, the familiarity of having to reassure Adora, a few words are stuck in her head. Broken. Failsafe. Responsibility. Friendship. *Crippling self-doubts*.

The sound of the door startles her enough to send a shiver through her spine as if she is suddenly afraid of someone barging in to blame her for not having done enough. A nervous giggle escapes her lips. 'Is it how Adora feels all the time? Regretting not having done more even when you know nothing could be done?'

"Glimmer? Is everything alright?" Bow swiftly closes the door and comes near her.

But if there is one difference between her and Adora or Catra, it's that she doesn't mind reaching for kindness, for help or comfort. She jumps into Bow's arms and a few tears naturally start flowing down her cheeks. Bow simply hugs her and runs a hand through her hair slowly, then waits, for her to talk when she is ready to, because he knows she will, because between the two of them they know that talking helps unconditionally.

"Did we do enough for Adora? Did we dictate too much and then let her down? Shouldn't we have done more to make her face how bad she was hurting herself by playing the *forced* hero?" Glimmer questions are sudden and Bow has to take a little time to make sure he understands them correctly. She waits patiently while wiping her tears with her sleeve, because she knows he will.

"I think we are good friends, Glimmer. We stayed at her side all the way, we never put She-Ra before Adora, we helped her recognise *some* mistakes-"

"Don't sugar coat it like me!" Glimmer strongly retorts. She doesn't want to hear what *she* would answer. "Please?" She adds more softly, because Bow deserves it.

"We did what we could. We tried to give her space while pushing our friendship onto her. We tried to guide her without walking

over her free will. We took every little parts we could here and there to alleviate her burden while respecting her choices. We believe in her. But she is She-Ra, there are things she is bound to feel responsible for. We don't have the power to make everything suddenly right but we never left her side-"

"I did!" Glimmer interrupts. "I left you both-"

"And you paid for it heavily. There is nothing more to do about-"

"I felt so guilty," She interrupts again. "yet I didn't even thought about taking the Failsafe myself. It felt so natural to let She-Ra-"

"I did." At his words, Glimmer stops and raises her head to look at him.

"How?"

"I'm not a princess. I never really had any big responsibility. Even at home, I'm the thirteenth kid, every expectations were already fulfilled long before me. When things like that happen, like the Failsafe, I always think *This time, it's my turn*. My turn to do something bigger than me, my turn to carry the big weight on my shoulders, but also my turn to face bigger consequences. I would be dead. I hesitated, then it was too late. I can't honestly say that I regret taking the time to hesitate with my life on the balance."

"But everyone would have been safe, Adora too. Maybe Catra was right for trying to stop her and maybe we should not have let Adora do so much either."

"Yes, I think she's right, but I also think her point-of-view doesn't have to apply to us. At that moment, she let her feelings talk when we were being reasonable. Her feelings for Adora are just that strong. I don't think she planned to take the Failsafe herself, she just was the only one to voice what her heart wanted. That doesn't make us bad. We all have times when we act out of reason and others when we act out of love."

"But we love Adora too, don't we?"

"It was her life with a chance of surviving against ours with a certain death at the end."

"Wasn't there anything we could have done?" *Crippling self-doubts*. Glimmer can't chase the words out of her mind as she questions everything.

"Like what? Force Shadow Weaver to do it, since she was probably the one less likely to be missed? Yeah, that feels like the *right* thing to do! We did the only things we could. Stay with Adora, smile, act like everything was fine to reassure her."

"But Catra-"

"Catra is a different story! She's Adora's whole world! And Adora is hers. If they want to change for each other, good for them, otherwise we can only stay and watch over them as they recover slowly now that we are at peace."

Glimmer chortles a little. "Yeah, that was my conclusion too… but I'm not sure anymore… I want to do more." *Overwhelming hubris*. The thought whirls again in her head. "I shouldn't do more, should I?"

"We can't force Adora to change any more than we did already. If anything we pushed our ideas onto her too much. Remember how you dragged her back to Bright Moon at the beginning?"

"But that was the right thing to do!"

"Yes, it was. But it was easy because there was a right and a wrong. Adora's issues now are not something so simple. We are here for her whatever happens, that's our place as best friends. Initiating a bigger change in Adora's heart is Catra's because they are ready to give everything for each other. That change will hurt Adora, make her face dreadful things from her past that she doesn't want to; we can't choose that for her but Catra can because she would give her life to help Adora go through this. I like Adora but we need to stay realistic here; I would risk a lot for her but not give away my life, not for her." Bow starts to blush a

little. In his attempt to justify himself, he also faces the fact that he can act like Catra, but for Glimmer only.

"Oh. But, then, you could do it for m-"

"That's how we ended up in space!" Bow interrupts, red spreading across his face. "Adora couldn't help herself, Entrapta was crazy about space, and *I* was willing to do anything to get you back. I know we made travelling out there feels like a casual field trip but really it wasn't. Darla was in no shape to fly safely and we knew barely enough to understand what we were doing. We didn't know what Prime had in store for us, half of the ship's systems weren't functioning completely, even the engine failed if you remember… And despite all that, I would do it all over again, because that choice, my choice, was to get you back whatever could happen to me." Despite the heat in his cheeks, his eyes are glued to his girlfriend's.

"You really did that for me." Glimmer's sentence is almost a question, almost, because she realises when speaking the words that there is no doubt about it.

"Yes, because I love you, Glimmer." That achieves to make Bow's face as red as physically possible, ears included, and he finally tries to look away but Glimmer cups his cheeks with her hands and makes him face her again to kiss him.

"I love you too." She kisses him again. She hesitates to talk for a moment but stops, even with his face all red Bow is smiling softly. She knows she's equally blushing and smiling, and doesn't even need to say aloud that she would do anything for him too.

"You're late." Catra is already in bed when Adora comes back to their room.

"I know. I'm sorry." Adora quickly changes and slides under the cover.

“I don’t want your sorry. Why are you sorry, we didn’t plan anything.” Catra turns around to face the wall in the opposite direction.

“I’m so…” Adora has to kick an imaginary self in her head. *Being sorry for the world*. ‘Right, part of the problem...’ She breathes and focuses. “Can we talk?”

“I don’t want to talk. I’m tired.”

“But yesterday you-”

“I did it because I had to. Now give me a break. I’m new to this. It’s exhausting and uncomfortable. You had a few more years of *training* than me for it...”

“O- Okay…”

“I probably talked more about myself in those last two days than in the rest of my life! I need time and space...”

“I can give you all the time you want, Catra, but I can’t give you space,” Adora pauses as she puts a hand on Catra’s shoulder. She lets her sentence hang in the air long enough for Catra to finally turn around and look at her questioningly. “the bed is too small.” Adora finishes, harbouring a wide smirk.

Catra is not able to silence a small giggle at her dumb girlfriend and shoves a pillow in her face. “I’m being serious!”

“Yeah, me too.” Adora loops her arms around Catra and holds her tightly against her. “I meant it. I’ll wait until you want to talk again but I won’t let go of you.”

Catra growls but the pillow drops aside and she sinks a little more into Adora’s embrace and smiles, eyes closed. “Since it doesn’t seem that important, please later?” She tucks her head under Adora’s chin.

Later should be fine; it's not like Adora has to say anything urgent in the first place, she realises, and a dangerous thought crosses her mind. They don't need to talk about it at all. She already said to Catra yesterday that she was going to do something about her issues. Did she seriously only want to brag about her decision? Does it mean nothing if she can't say 'Look how strong I am, changing is no big deal for me!' That's not the point, is it? She wants to change to become better for Catra, not to be praised for it.

Feeling Adora's agitation, Catra growls again but it's soft this time, almost sweet. "I'm listening if *you* have something to say though." She murmurs.

Listening. When was the last time Adora listened to someone else, before yesterday? She shouldn't need to, she doesn't need to. Listening means that she is wrong, listening means that she is weak, that she needs help and advice, that she can't do something on her own. Adora is scared of listening because it denies what she thinks she is, what she was taught and raised to be: perfect.

Adora listened when Catra told her she was sorry. She listened when Catra said she loved her. But those were alright, Adora was desperate, she wanted to hear those words so much. *Those were easy*. She listened when… she listened… A dreadful shiver runs along her spine as she realises that she can't think of anything meaningful.
She didn't listen the first time Catra tried to tell her how blind she was growing up.
She didn't listen to Catra when she left.
She didn't listen to Catra when Catra left.
She didn't listen when she left Glimmer. The queen was wrong… but that's not the point, she didn't listen.
Adora can't recall another time when she really listened. How often did people try to talk, to offer help, to ask her to look in a mirror and realise what she was doing to herself?

Her mind is in shambles and in the midst of the whirlwind formed by her thoughts she realises that she is wrong. There is one voice she constantly listened to, one voice that took all her strength to silence. A sweetly frightening voice. A familiar voice. Shadow Weaver's voice. Adora starts to panic, yesterday Catra forced her to listen for once and the princess wonders how much did she miss before that. She wanted to talk to Catra again so lightly, about something so serious, she underestimated her own issues so much. She didn't plan anything, hasn't thought past 'I have to talk to Catra about it!' and apparently even for the wrong reason!

"Mmhmm..." A very soft sound as Catra shifts in her arms. Adora stills herself and looks at her tenderly, abandoning her previous thoughts for a moment. Even asleep, Catra has that much effect on her. Asleep. Adora's heart almost stops. Catra looks really exhausted. The princess didn't notice. No, actually she didn't look. Content, yes, happy, comfy, sure, but exhausted. Catra said she was tired and Adora didn't listen either, again.

Catra made so many efforts to open up and talk, talk some more and talk again during the last few days. What did Adora do? Sure they spent quality time together and worked on their feelings for each other but that didn't require that much *efforts* since there was enough love. Their talks helped a lot but Adora has been getting used to talk since meeting Glimmer and Bow; *she* didn't find it that difficult to open up, but Catra did. They face the result of a war together but as pained and regretful as Adora is, Catra is much more. What did Adora do while Catra braved all that and worked so hard? Nothing. It didn't feel like nothing, she thought she was doing a lot, she worked hard to rebuild but that's not the question. She thought a lot but did anything even come out of it? Last night's conversation comes back to her mind again as she's looking at Catra. *Broken*. She is running in circles like a wrecked skiff and a *Shadow* is starting to whisper in her mind.

You have a job to do.

'I need to fix this!' No, that's wrong, that's absolutely wrong! That's not how she is supposed to think anymore. Catra tried so

hard to make her understand.

You made the right choice.

'I have to get better.' No, wrong, wrong wrong! It's not a choice if she *has to*.

She's your responsibility.

'I need to take care of Catra.' Wrong, wrong again, that's not how she should think, certainly not the way Catra wants her to think! 'Wants. I want…'

Don't be selfish.

'I want to change... That's not too much, right?' Her friends all told her she was allowed to want a little and Catra made her accept that she needed a little selfishness to save the world.

You need to do a better job!

'I want to change because Catra asked me to.' Better but still wrong. She can't drop the responsibility of that choice onto Catra.

You have a greater purpose!

'I want to get better so I can be happy. That will make Catra happier too.' A simple goal. Then maybe they'll find a *greater* purrrpose together. Adora is about to cry, barely hiding it behind her dumb sarcastic pun.

Don't you dare turn away from me!

'**Stop ruining me!**'

Adora nuzzles Catra's hair in tears to silence her insidious thoughts. She breathes deeply, lets Catra's warmth and faint sweet smell envelop her, and listening to her girlfriend slow breathing soothes her racing heart. There's no way she will let Catra's efforts go to waste. It takes her a long time but with the

girl she loves sleeping peacefully in her arms, she starts to work again, calmly this time, through the first issue she can. What does Catra need and want her to be. Not what she thought Catra wants her to be, not what she thought she should be, not what others hope she is, and certainly definitely not what *she believed* others hope she is.

It takes a long time and as the sun is about to rise, Adora makes a promise to herself. She will get better. Not *fix*, not in that twisted way she was taught she has to *correct* everything, but truly heal because Catra deserves it.

Adora has weaknesses. She hid them behind her false-confidence and behind She-Ra's strength for too long. She starts to understand how better she is at lying to herself than lying to others. Catra is so much stronger than her and yet here she is, dreaming comfortably in her embrace because Adora *can* be strong too, can be *safe*. She'll get help if- when... she… She *will* get help, as many as she needs because Catra is simply worth it, worth dropping her wretched pride, worth looking in a mirror, worth a *true* effort.

It takes a long time and that night Adora doesn't sleep much but she doesn't care. At least she realises that it's part of the issue too but this time it's selfish, openly acceptedly selfish, and not hidden behind excuses of works and duties. In a few hours she will join Glimmer and discuss where to begin and she will listen because she chose that obscure path and her friend can light it up with *Sparkles*.

The first of a long list of *help* she never thought she was allowed to reach for before- wrong, she never thought she needed.

The first step that belongs to her and her only, without a *Shadow* of obligations and expectations looming over.

The first step with her thoughts free, not unconsciously *Woven* stuck together against her will.

Sleepover

It happens a few days later. Settling down in their new life comes easier than expected while they both find a somewhat comfortable routine to keep their feelings, the good as much as the bad, in check. Peace definitely suits Adora better than war even though she misses the action but there is still a lot of diplomacy to do and quarrels to subdue... The thing is, the reflection in her mirror is smiling more often than before. Catra being here helps in that regard as well, obviously. Is it obvious? For people who know her at least, it's pretty obvious… She can't hide anything from showing on her face after all!

It also comes from the fact that she is going forward for once. A real forward, not toward an unavoidable duty or in a circle. Since she began seeing Perfuma and others regularly she feels better. Her troubles haven't magically disappeared but the simple fact of doing something about them helps her so much more than she could have imagined. There are ups and downs, but always a path to follow and someone to point out lessons to learn even from failures.

However, as bad as Adora's issues were depicted by Catra, they are soft in comparison to the feline girl's own problems. Now that she doesn't feel like she has to sacrifice herself anymore, that is. Ruining her slowly, eating her from inside, if not treated, certainly, and she is very grateful to Catra to have forced her to open her eyes. But not violent. And that's why she didn't notice them earlier, Catra said, but at the same time her feline girlfriend is reluctant to look at her own faults, because she already has a lot to deal with regarding the recent past and the people she hurt.

They have put down a few rules, also supported by Glimmer, Catra hissed when Adora told her she wanted the queen's approval but that's another story, and one of these rules is that after dinner is *their* time. Adora isn't allowed to take any job that is sure to finish late and Catra has to leave a note if she needs space so much that she goes out.

Today is one of those days Melog is out with Swift Wind therefore Adora expects to find Catra waiting in their room when she pushes the door. She caught her feline girlfriend napping a few times already these days, because of all the efforts Catra puts in everything it feels natural, so she tries to be as quiet as possible.

And she finds her curled up in an odd ball at the foot of the bed. For a brief instant the view is absolutely cute and sweet but a few memories then hit Adora like punches. The last time she saw Catra this way was before they grew apart. Another time, another life almost, when their feelings weren't yet connected together, and a shiver runs along her spine.

Adora had to look at the whole picture when she started working on her issues, from the start, from when she was little and taken in by Shadow Weaver and the Horde, and one downside is that now she sees everything from the past in a potential negative way. Like right now, maybe Catra is simply comfortable in this position, it's not something they had occasions to discuss, but all Adora can see is Catra acting like a pet, as Shadow Weaver wanted.

And Adora hates it. Before Catra opens her eyes, before she talks, Adora already feels like her feline girlfriend ended up like this instead of lying simply on the bed because she had a hard time today and needs comfort. Maybe people hurt her again, maybe something made her remember the past, maybe… Adora sits on the side of the bed and puts a hand on Catra's shoulder. Or maybe she thinks too much and Catra just likes sleeping this way but that last possibility doesn't linger long enough in her mind to stick.

"Catra, are you-"

Catra hisses and jumps at the touch. Adora pulls back her hand instantly and she doesn't need Catra to point out that her concern shows very strongly on her face. The feline girl barely takes one look at it and her surprise becomes anger. With her fur already standing on end, her ears flattened and her tail bushed, curled

around herself, she looks threatening and the sight makes Adora even more concerned.

“Don’t come in there with that ugly face!” Catra shouts hysterically and the tone rubs Adora in all the wrong ways when she is truly worried about her.

“Well, sorry, I was born with it!”

“You know what I mean!”

“Yeah? Then you know how you look too!”

“What?! I was calmly asleep, waiting for you!”

“And you had to be like this on the bed?”

“I get it, I can’t use *your* bed like I want, ‘s that it?”

“It’s your bed too!” Adora already knows that the whole argument isn’t going to make sense and probably will not end well but what can she do?

“Then let me be!”

“Catra, I’m worried about you!”

“Why?! I can take care of myself! *Leave me alone!*”

Adora doesn’t want to, really doesn’t, but right now she is scared of worsening the situation just as much if she stays. She realises that she already has taken a few steps back and turns away to face the door. She waits a few seconds with her hand on the handle before leaving, hoping that Catra will speak again, ask her to stay, but there is only silence and she gets out, quietly as well.

Catra instantly regrets her last words once the door closes again but the anger is strong, and even if she didn’t mean the last part, there are still reasons for her to be angry. They talked about it. Catra talked about it! Despite being very uncomfortable with such

personal words. She wants Adora's attention, sure, but she hates when Adora is being overly worried about her even more. And everything shows on the princess' face.

Sometime ago, on the ship after being saved, Catra hated Adora's big dopey smile full of hope and love, when all she deserved- at least what she thought she deserved, was hate and contempt. But she is changing, she wants this smile so much now, why can't Adora get that?! Her smile was hurting because it showed how wrong Catra was but she is trying not to be wrong anymore and that smile is now the best sight in the world. Adora knows! Should know...

Why was there no smile tonight when Catra wanted it?

A tingle of magic alerts Catra that Sparkles is coming and she composes herself, sits straight on the edge of the bed and scowls in advance. The queen appears with Adora and frowns back intently as soon as she makes eye contact with Catra.

"You two, I'm too tired to act like your mom tonight," Glimmer starts speaking in a commanding voice. "Therefore you'll have to deal with your troubles on your own. And since you both are really bad at it and really quick to run away you aren't allowed to leave this room until you talk. 'm not asking you to solve every world's problems, only that you make up and *calmly* discuss the issue. Adora, if you leave this room, I'm making you sit with me all day long without doing anything tomorrow during the most boring meeting you'll ever know." Glimmer then teleports in front of Catra, grabs her shoulders strongly and leans menacingly forward. "Catra, if you even think about fleeing before talking with Adora, I swear I'm gonna teleport you all over Etheria until you pu- *pass out*!"

And just like that the queen disappears again. The two other girls are left there speechless for a moment, not that Glimmer being bossy is new but usually not in such a dramatic fashion.

“What did you say to her?” Catra shouts after coming back to her senses, her voice unmistakably blaming Adora for Sparkles’ meddling.

“Nothing! I didn’t even speak! As soon as she saw me coming back, she grabbed me, and here we are!”

“Whatever… what are you gonna do about this?” Catra replies more calmly. It’s unfair but she can’t do anything about it now. She chased Adora away, so of course the blonde girl went to Sparkles, and when the queen saw Adora’s distraught face she obviously was going to do something. Catra just didn’t expect *this*.

“Talk?” Adora’s word makes her wince, thus the princess elaborates a little. “I mean, you can just listen to me if you don’t want to answer, but what do we have to lose?”

“Being even more angry? Saying shit we don’t mean and hurt each other? Why does she think that talking always means being honest and that it’s positive?! I know I have my *talk moments* these days too but it doesn’t mean every time is good!”

“Catra, you know that when we don’t talk it always ends badly…” Adora sighs.

Catra growls in annoyance but doesn’t move and Adora carefully approaches to sit down beside her, leaving a little distance between the two of them. Not much, just enough for Catra to be able to choose. If she leans a little her way, the feline girl can make contact with the princess easily. She doesn’t for now.

“If we have to talk about it, I would rather do this sooner than later. I’m not very good at being patient...” Adora says, trying to be soft and open.

“No kidding! But what about what *I* want?”

“Do you seriously want me gone?!”

“No? But can’t you just be there and smile and *not* talk?”

“N- no. I didn’t mean to scare you when I came back. I’m sorry.”

“Why not? And you didn’t scare me!”

“Because I’m hurt and you are too, and I want to fix- *make this better*. Sorry I *startled* you then!”

“Why are you hurt?! I’m the one who’s hurt! Stop being sorry for shit!”

“Catra, you told me to leave you!”

“You know I didn’t mean permanently!”

“It still hurts! You told me to not act like I’m perfect in front of you, well here I am, hurt and sad and worried and angry because you won’t accept that I am sharing your pain, and I can’t always stay all good and positive to comfort you!”

“Oh, yeah, princess, because I aaaalways need you to comfort me! Can’t you at least shut up?”

“Glimmer told us to talk! What else do you expect me to do?!”

“Why are you so fixated on obeying *her* like this?!”

“Because-”

Purple lights of magic interrupt Adora, and Glimmer appears again, with Bow this time. “When I said you had to talk, I didn’t mean making the entire castle listen to you.”

“Sparkles, can you stay out of this?”

“Sure, sure… can I watch?”

“Glimmer!” Bow suddenly shouts at her reaction.

“What? They want to fight, we may as well crash their little fun and enjoy the show! We even brought snacks!” She answers with a malicious grin, pointing at the large bag he is holding.

“Glimmer, I don’t think you are helping.” Adora notes, her reasons for blindly obeying the queen wavering.

“Too bad, *tonight* I’m not. What. a. shock!” Glimmer theatrically holds a hand to her forehead and sighs.

“Why is everyone so annoying today?!” Catra growls.

“You are acting like a spoiled kid, fine by me, I can do that too!” The queen replies instantly.

She teleports on the bed behind Catra and swiftly loops her arms around the feline girl’s waist. She hugs her tightly, resting her cheek against Catra’s neck, and Catra freezes having no idea how to respond to this. Not so long ago, she would have hurt anyone acting like this but that’s not who she wants to be anymore. Certainly not with Sparkles at least.

At the sight, Adora has a moment of pure and innocent jealousy and she embraces Catra from the side. Bow giggles and, as to follow the trend, puts the bag down on the floor and comes to sit on the bed on the other side of Catra and soon hugs her lightly too. She finally tries to struggle out of it but too late; with the three of them it’s impossible without getting violent.

“Sparkles, what’s the meaning of this?!”

“What’s with the bag?” Adora interrupts but she is royally ignored.

“I’m taking a break at being a *good nice princess*! I’m doing what I want, there’s no deep meaning behind it.”

“We thought-” Bow tries to answer Adora but he is cut by Catra.

“*Personal space*, all of you?”

“Yeah, right. Convenient excuse.” Glimmer dismisses. “Catra, when I was very young, I had a tutor who really needed their own space.”

“Poor them! Did they survive?” Catra snickers.

“Yeah, barely! Mom had to explain to me over and over again what it meant, until I got curious enough to try to understand them!”

“Then why-”

“I don’t believe for one second that you are like that with us now! You use this excuse when you are scared and want to push people away because you are still too familiar with loneliness! If you want to convince me otherwise, you’ll have to do a lot better than this. As I said, tonight I don’t care much about indulging and working slowly with you. I want contact, deal with it.”

“Seriously, what’s with the bag?” Adora tries again.

“It’s not like you need to hug *me*! Hug Bow! Or even Adora!” Catra ignores the blonde girl too.

“Nope. Tonight I want to hug you.” Sparkles continues.

“It’s sl-” Bow can’t finish his sentence again.

“Adora, can you do something about her?! She is crazier than usual!”

“I don’t think I can, I have no idea what’s going on either!” Adora answers but tightens her arms around Catra as to not lose to Glimmer’s enthusiasm.

“You don’t get it, do you?” The queen asks more softly.

“Get what?!” Catra hisses.

"I told you aboard Darla that we were kind because you needed it in order to heal and change. Well, that's over now. You did. Good job! No more therapy kindness for you, now you have to earn it.”

“Exactly, I’m being annoying and selfish and hurtful, so let me go!” Catra blurts out.

“Yeah. You are. What about it? You seem to regret it; do better next time!”

“Then hug me next time! Right now you should stay away! Why-”

“Catra, you dummy, because we love *you* too, of course! Even when you are being difficult! And that’s how we show it! If we did that only during good times, it would be pointless!”

Catra tenses up in the middle of the hug. Sparkles always has a way to make her feel like a little kid struggling with her emotions when she talks like this, even if tonight she is more direct than usual. And she wants to hate it, because it’s unfair and conceited, and hard to accept that some people are understanding her even when she tries to hide her feelings. But once again she feels safe and warm, surrounded by all those arms, and it makes her hate only herself for being like this. But if she really can’t push them away, if they won’t leave… Maybe it’s okay. Maybe *she* is okay after all...

“So. What’s with the-” Adora tries once more.

“Sleepover stuff! Can’t you tell?” Glimmer finally answers with an ounce of annoyance in her voice. “It’s the same bag as always!”

“Glimmer, you have like, ten of those.” Bow counters more softly.

“But they are all different!” She whines for the dramatic effect of it and gives Catra a little squeeze to get her attention back. “So, Catra, you get one chance out of this. You better think carefully before you answer. Up for a Best Friend Squad sleepover?” Sparkles giggles. “We brought games and snacks!”

“Maybe I should leave you three-” Catra hesitates.

“No way. But we can throw Adora out if you don’t want to see her face!”

“Hey, it’s my room too!” The princess retorts.

“Well, sorry, it’s my castle.” Glimmer resumes her dramatics. “Oh, wait, I’ve got a better idea!” In a swift motion and a spark of magic, she takes Adora’s ponytail and puff off, and brushes the princess’ hair forward to make it fall on her face, hiding most of it. And she goes back to hugging Catra with both arms as soon as she’s done, of course.

Catra takes a good look at Adora who is laughing and shaking her head in an attempt to shift her hair aside because her hands are busy holding her girlfriend right now. Catra glances at Sparkles over her shoulder; the queen also has a radiant smile on her face. And Bow, well, when is he *not* smiling? *This* seems better than arguing with Adora, if she’s stuck in here anyway.

Stuck.

No. Not stuck, she can leave whenever she wants but they are trying to show her that she *belongs* with them, and it’s working when she doesn’t let her fears and anxiety get in the way.

Here.

Catra wants to be here with Adora and… For the first time she realises that there are already a few more people in her heart than she wants to admit. For so long there was only Adora, she was only allowed to have Adora, pushed to believe she had enough space only for one, Adora. But she has all the evidences she needs to know she was wrong, and they are doing their best to make her know that it’s not too late, even after everything. She has room for more; stars even to spite Shadow Weaver she would love to have more *friends*! Can she do that? Of course she can. If Sparkles can, she can too! She is smarter and stronger, and even at her worst she is less annoying than the queen!

Catra nods and a little “Okay” escapes her lips. She doesn’t glance at Sparkles’s face again but she knows there is a grin on it, irritating, soothing, as always, and she looks at Adora who makes

the same kind of expression. “Shut up!” Catra preventively commands.

“I didn’t- I didn’t say anything.” Adora answers cutely.

Bow lets go of Catra and starts pulling out the content of the bag. The three girls stare at him as if they expect some kind of surprise, when they actually know it’s only simple sleepover stuff. Sleeping bags, snacks, games.

“Can you believe we started doing this at first because Adora couldn’t sleep alone when she first came to Bright Moon?”

Catra laughs and finally relaxes, and at first that worries her. Usually, mentions of the time they were separated are painful. But if she wants she can still be part of this. Those people are making sure of it and share the memories piece by piece to not suffocate her.

“Actually,” Glimmer starts again a little shy. “I’ve been wanting to have a sleepover with you for a long time now. We spoke about the ones we had with Adora over and over, but now we can really do this together.”

“I love you.” Adora whispers, when she feels that Catra has calmed down and really accepted the idea.

The feline girl’s ears twitch. Those words are absolutely unfair, and wonderful, and they remind her how much she loves this blonde girl too, all of her, her faults, her perfection, and even the overly-goodness she represents. Catra’s tail manages to struggle past Sparkles and loops around Adora’s waist tightly.

“Hey, no flirting while I’m hugging you!”

Catra smirks. She pulls Adora’s head softly, brushes the hair out of her face and kisses her lips.

“Stars you are annoying…” Sparkles retorts but she is laughing. She lets go of Catra, mostly, she slides on the bed to sit next to

her instead of behind yet keeps an arm around the feline girl's back.

"So… what are we playing?"

The Cat and the princess

Adora is stuck in a loop. Yesterday she woke Catra up again from a nap and it made her feline girlfriend jump and hiss, and look at her briefly as if Adora was out to hurt her, *again*. It shouldn't be *that* dreadful, after all the things that they lived through, yet the princess' feelings can't settle down. Catra's reaction isn't exactly surprising but the most recent and violent of those awakenings took place aboard Darla, shortly after taking her back from Prime. Not the kindest of memories and the simple thought of them makes Adora shudder.

And now she has another unexpected problem; she never thought about it before, but when her feline girlfriend acts like a cat, the princess can't keep the idea out of her head that Catra behaves this way because Shadow Weaver forced her to in order to make her feel like a pet, inferior and worthless, and this is something that the blonde girl can't accept.

Long ago, when Catra and she were kids, Adora had only one way to approach this kind of things. She always pushed and pushed, until they fought; that was one of their ways to communicate, she thought. But after being really separated and reunited, making Catra leave and got her back once more, Adora doesn't want to be too insistent either, because she knows that her pushiness played its part in their mismatched feelings. And now thinking about the past really emphasises the blonde girl's naturally high anxiety.

Yesterday at the sight of Catra's distress, Adora could instantly feel it surging, which made Catra's face ignite from anger just as quickly in turn, because the feline girl simply hates when Adora looks like the world is ending, even more so now that they managed to prevent it. The princess thought she could bear with it this time but unfortunately, Catra rejecting her concern was too much to handle. It all just felt unavoidable and there was no Glimmer to calm things down between them this time.

Therefore to not repeat the disaster of the previous day, Adora fled the room as fast as she could and both girls awkwardly avoided each other until well after dinner, and only managed to speak again when it was time to say goodnight. Sure they didn't yell at each other in the meantime, which was better, somehow… maybe... or maybe not; the result wasn't any more pleasant and they didn't solve anything.

This evening Adora doesn't want a replay of either of those last two days, but she still has no idea how to do that. She is pacing back and forth in front of her room's door, trying to put her thoughts in order, but it's an exercise in which she is really not as efficient as she hoped. Planning is her thing, usually, but procrastinating is it just as much, and it's been well over half an hour and she hasn't made any progress.

The loop seems inevitable. She wakes up Catra, who panics, making Adora worry which turns into something a lot darker since the princess is already feeling bad for her acting all *pet-like*, and this angers Catra way too much for Adora to ignore, because she means well and the feline girl *should* know it...

When the princess got back, she glimpsed inside the room to check that Catra was indeed there and asleep, once again in that weird ball cat posture at the foot of the bed, and that simply made her freeze in place. It took her a whole minute to finally move and breathe again, and she chose to step back outside to gain some time to think about this.

On one hand, Catra's cat side is very attractive. Adora isn't sure if the feline girl is actually related to cats because Entrapta has yet to successfully obtain a sample of Catra's blood to verify that theory. Anyway, the result probably wouldn't do anything against Adora's uneasiness about comparing Catra to… pets. That's the other hand.

For so long she had kept a blind eye at Shadow Weaver treating Catra like one, and Adora knows that in some good measure she acted not so differently when she was young. Catra was soft,

plushy, warm, the perfect little thing to hug and cuddle, and the blonde girl usually didn't care much about Catra's opinion on that matter. Shadow Weaver taught Adora that Catra was *hers* and that she was responsible for her, and despite Adora simply thinking of her as a friend, she still *acted* the part because she didn't care.

But Catra cared and she resented Adora for not understanding, and now the princess knows that her oblivious behaviour played an important part in dividing the two of them. She wants to avoid making Catra feel inferior with all her might, and that very cat-like position in which Catra naps doesn't help at all because Adora won't forgive herself if she allows herself to find it *cute*, and discovers later that it's a sign that Catra had a bad day and feels terrible, and that really irritates Adora, and worries her, and saddens her, and-

"Adora? What are you doing?"

The sudden voice makes the blonde girl jump up and she lets escape a squeak way too high pitched for her usual *cool* standards. "Catra?! Why are you awake?"

The feline girl frowns deeply at Adora's inappropriate phrasing at first. But the princess isn't known for her wording skills, except for a few motivational speeches maybe, and Catra knows this well enough to calm down, let it slide, and her expression shifts to a faint smirk at Adora's clumsiness. The blonde girl blushes and looks away awkwardly, which definitely makes Catra want to tease her instead of scolding her, and the feline girl starts to laugh when two guards arrive running, alerted by Adora's weird shout earlier, and throwing the princess into an embarrassed soft panic.

"Shall we go get dinner?" asks Catra once the blonde girl has convinced the soldiers that everything is fine.

Adora nods and Catra quickly passes before her. Although the princess guesses that the feline girl's easy mood switch has something to do with avoiding the previous days' situation just as

much as Adora wants to, and both of them try to act as if nothing is wrong. But it's not an issue she can simply forget about; or is Adora destined to never wake up Catra again?

Dinner is spent without many words, then the night comes, then another day of hard work, and the loop starts again. For the fourth evening in a row Adora stands in front of her door, wondering how to escape it.

"What are you doing?"

Adora is startled today again, but at least manages to not yell this time around, partly because it's not Catra's voice. "Entrapta?! Hey, hi, how are you doing? Haven't seen you in a while!"

"Heya! I'm good! I've been so busy with the new network! I'm working with Bow right now and..."

Adora half listens to the other princess' enthusiastic explanation of her plans for one or another tech that Prime left behind. Usually these science discoveries and tech progresses are good opportunities to get her mind out of anything heavy that she's wrapped in, but it doesn't work tonight. Catra is not a subject she can put aside and on the contrary it makes her feel even more frustrated to not be able to solve anything in comparison. Entrapta's sudden change of tone manages to fully get her attention again.

"… Adora, are you okay?"

The direct question surprises the blonde girl who has no time to formulate anything else than a hesitant "Yes?".

The answer doesn't convince Entrapta in the slightest, which is not surprising since Adora looks even more concerned than her voice sounded. Despite Entrapta's trouble with people she is very observant, and as true as she has no idea what to say, she can't ignore the issue either. She simply stays there, staring at Adora and waits for the blonde girl to correct herself on her own.

It doesn’t take long for Adora to start talking, because Entrapta being Entrapta helps. She gives off that warm impression that she’s listening closely, yet not too closely, and Adora feels like she can just stop whenever she wants and get away with a simple ‘never mind’, if the situation becomes too awkward. It doesn’t, and the blonde princess proceeds to summarise her present situation.

“… and that’s where I am now. Any idea?”

“I’m not too sure about the *cat* thing, but… can’t you just hide your face when you wake her up?” Entrapta instantly replies.

“It’s not that simple!”

“It isn’t? Anyway, I have to go, there is soooooo much to do with all that new tech! See ya!”

Adora waves and the geek princess disappears as quickly as she appeared. The blonde girl sighs deeply. No progress today either but at least she is a little more relaxed now, after talking with someone else… ‘or maybe saying *talking to* someone else would be more accurate?’ she asks herself and chuckles. ‘Hiding my face...’

One...

Two...

Three...

A few seconds. That’s what Catra needs, every time that she wakes up, to remember where she is.

And more importantly where she isn’t.

A few breathes, way too many heartbeats, to fully understand that she is safe.

When she wakes up naturally, all this happens while she is still between dream and reality, and only her body really gives signs of her distress once her mind is fully conscious, like the remnants of a hazy nightmare. Bushy fur, ears flatten, and sometimes her claws are all out too which is now her main concern. She has gotten used to this since her rescue from Prime and most of the time there is a sleeping Adora not far which tremendously helps her calm down quickly. Catra aligns her breathing with the blonde girl's, tries to get her heartbeats to match those of her princess, and just like that the lingering dread of the moment is gone and all that's left needed is a bit of grooming.

But when she is awoken in the middle of a deep sleep, it's a different story. And the fact that it's quite new doesn't help; she isn't used to sleep so soundly. There was always something that kept her sleep light before; all sorts of dangers and unwanted surprises, anxiety, pain, also an unconscious wish to keep an eye on Adora maybe? Angst, fear… Whenever she would slip from her own bed to sleep at the foot of Adora's, she would wake up at the slightest movement or the faintest sound, to be able to escape before getting caught.

Yet now in the comfort and peace of their room in Bright Moon, with the Horde gone, her body easily forgets all those years of training and simply slumbers deeply at the slightest occasion, as if to catch up with all those times it couldn't. Adora's arms help too, or her smell that the bed retains in her absence, and also the absurdly high amount of work that the queen asks of Catra these days, that leaves her utterly exhausted.

Sparkles isn't shy from efforts herself but while she compensates with long nights, Catra is used to short ones and often needs a nap before evening. And that's without taking into account that Adora and her have already spent a few nights talking instead of sleeping… or doing other *things*. And a sleepover three nights ago. And they ended a war just recently. And...

And all this would be perfectly fine and irrelevant if Adora wasn't always overreacting! But that's the main issue now for Catra. She

doesn’t mind the fatigue; she rather likes naps. Although waking up thinking that she’s still Prime’s captive is terrifying, it passes quickly. She is now strong enough to not let this drown her, and on the scale of all the things that she has to deal with, it’s only mildly annoying, far less so than seeing that anguished look that Adora has *sadly* become so proficient at!

‘Yes, I have a bad time being woken up, and? When it’s done, it’s done, and Adora should be done looking like it’s the end of the world too!’ sighs Catra.

But unfortunately the princess stays stuck into her worries until she can take action against their source. Yet here’s the problem: Catra doesn’t need anything but Adora herself. And what irritates Catra the most is that this is a part of Adora that changed along the years, even more so the last few they were separated.

When they were young, the blonde girl knew so well how to sooth Catra; running after her when needed and simply sticking with her as long as necessary. Nothing else was required of her to help the feline girl, not even a contact, not a word, just her presence. Back then, Adora stayed entire nights with Catra doing mostly nothing. Playing stupid games, humming songs maybe, but nothing more; certainly not digging into her problems. And that’s exactly what Catra needed and still needs. But Adora doesn’t seem to be able to not do anything significant anymore and always tries to act or talk or…

It always ends with her agonizing over what she should do to help Catra. Then this pain shows on the princess’ face and Catra hates this more than anything. Of course the issue isn’t Adora’s beautiful face in itself, it’s what its expression means deep inside the princess’ mind.

Sparkles is at fault too since she taught Adora to talk about her problems. Every. single. problem. And it’s not really wrong but in this instance it’s backfiring because Adora is Adora; always rushing in, never relaxing, taking every weights on her own shoulders, therefore she wants to talk about Catra’s problems

without considering that maybe there's nothing to talk about. The feline girl might be somewhat at fault too for not giving the blonde girl any hint either but what is she supposed to say, 'Take me in your arms and shut up? Like that would end well!!' It didn't, the last time that she tried to silence Adora.

Just like this, Catra is awoken from her nap today too. For those brief seconds before opening her eyes she can see tanks full of a green liquid behind her eyelids. A dreadful chant echoes in her head and her ears flatten in an attempt to mute it. She is in Bright Moon, she knows it, yet has trouble believing it. She feels a clawed hand trying to push her under the surface of a pool of that same green fluid. Adora is here beside her; Catra can smell her, recognises her heartbeat, yet it still seems like an illusion.

Everything happens in an instant, she can't help but hiss, growl and take a defensive posture as soon as she is awake enough to move. The hand touching her shoulder is surely Adora's, yet it takes some effort to not claw at it. Catra doesn't want to open her eyes. She knows what will happen then and she waits an extra second or two to calm down somewhat. She imagines Adora smiling, but it will make her feel even worse when she sees the princess' real face so she stops. She wonders if she should just keep her eyes closed but Adora will probably worry even more, making the situation worse too...

Catra slowly opens her eyes and readies herself to discover what kind of pained expression the blonde girl has for her today. But she can't see Adora's face and she has to blink twice to register that she's face to face with a pillow.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks simply, too stunned to say anything else for now.

"Nothing, nothing!" Adora can't help but scoff at her own behaviour. There is a short awkward silence before she resigns herself to speak again, still hidden behind her pillow. "How was your day?"

“It was fine until I got woken up by a talking pillow?” Catra scoffs hesitantly.

Adora lowers said pillow and hugs it tightly against her chest. Catra flinches. Adora’s face looks exactly like what she expected a moment ago and her grin falls. It’s even more irritating since Adora’s behaviour indicates that the princess is conscious of it and Catra needs to bite her lips to not let escape a few less-than-flattering comments. But that only makes Adora look even more sour.

“Catra, are you o-”

“Stop it! … *please*?” Catra’s last word feels so forced that it has trouble leaving her mouth and it doesn’t seem to appease Adora’s growing concern.

“Can we talk-”

Catra flinches once more. *talk*. There’s that word again, reminding her how much Adora has changed, and she doesn’t want to acknowledge it as something positive, and certainly doesn’t want to deal with it when she is already in a bad mood. “No.” She sits up on the side of the bed besides Adora and takes a deep breath. It should have been a matter of seconds, but because of Adora’s behaviour, the dread of her sleep being roughly interrupted persists. She still needs the blonde girl close and her tail loops around the princess’ waist.

It’s Adora’s turn to flinch, unsure of what to make of the gap between Catra’s words and action. She opens her mouth to speak, stops, closes it, tries to think, in vain, her lips part again. Usually Catra is more unilaterally pushing or pulling, and Adora is bad with those ambiguous signs. She shuts her mouth once more and waits what seems to be an hour, but is five minutes in reality, during which Catra does nothing aside from glancing at her from time to time. The blonde girl has no idea how to read those eyes, so wanting, yet so calm despite this dicey situation.

The silence is really awkward and Adora doesn't move a muscle either. She fears that the slightest shift will make Catra pull her tail away and leave, or get even more angry. They haven't shared a word either and she dreads the moment when one of them will say something and all that tension built up will explode and ruin everything. When she can't bear it anymore, Adora jumps up and goes for the door to prevent this to happen.

"What are you doing?" Catra asks in an irritated voice.

Adora feels like this is a question that she has been asked repetitively during the last few days, in all kind of forms, and she wonders about that herself. She needs to connect with Catra but the feline girl doesn't let her. She wants to answer that it's all Catra's fault for pushing her away yet she can't resolve herself to blame Catra for anything. She wishes sometimes that she could simply shout 'I have no idea what I'm doing!' but She-Ra isn't allowed to do that. She needs a plan, she needs to think through all this before making a mistake. Right now she has to reply *anything* and get out of here as fast as possible. "I'll better leave you alone-"

"Why?!"

Adora didn't expect such a strong reaction from Catra and she tries to justify herself in a hurry. "You don't want to talk to me… Don't you want some space?"

"No?"

Adora freezes in place. Her brain is trying in vain to make sense of the situation, but she needs to, she can't act carelessly around Catra without a clear strategy to prevent either of them to get angry. She hears Catra calling her name from behind and she doesn't know how to answer. She wonders what may happen if she still reaches for the door as intended. She thought that it was a safe way to gain more time to work the problem but Catra clearly disagrees. She thought that anything was beating sitting so awkwardly on the bed, yet again Catra is not on the same page at

all. The feline girl calls her name once more and there's concern in her voice. Adora flinches once again. She is the one worrying about Catra, not the other way around, and weighing if she would rather have the feline girl angry or concerned only adds to her anxiety.

"If you are gonna keep making that face, then *I'm* the one leaving!" says Catra as she stands up and walks past Adora.

But before she can reach the door's handle, it slams open and a big growling alien *cat* enters followed by a winged unicorn. Melog looks at Catra as if she is a kitten that did something bad, and since they harbour their full size threateningly, they are topping the feline girl and looking down at her. Swift Wind stares at Adora in the same way, then gently but firmly headbutts her, and both girls don't have time to react before their two magical friends push them back one step, and another, and one more, and soon Adora and Catra stumble against the bed and fall back to sit on it side by side as before.

Melog lies in front of Catra and rests their head on her laps to keep her in place. They don't speak nor send images and ideas like they usually do to communicate, only grunt when Catra tries to move or speak. Beside them, Adora's protest is met by the same treatment from the unicorn and soon the room is completely silent, for a brief moment.

"Sooooo… what-" Swift Wind begins to ask but is promptly interrupted by Melog.

'No word.'

"Me too?!"

Melog simply nods.

Swift Wind neighs shortly to express his doubts, but nonetheless follows Melog's lead. He lies down on the floor in front of Adora and rests his head on the princess' knees to mirror the other pair, and the room is immersed in silence again.

A lot of thoughts pass through Catra's mind. The firsts being 'what am I doing here?' and 'Why am I obeying?' but it just *feels* wrong to go against her friend without hearing them out. If they want to speak, that is, because right now there's only silence as she wanted. And then there are all the questions about the two magical animals presence. She can sense a little of it through her bond with Melog when they are this close, and she guesses the rest. Both of them simply *felt* like there was trouble between Adora and her, and decided to rush here from whatever adventure they were off to.

There is a little bit of guilt looming over Catra briefly, to have Melog and Swift Wind interrupt whatever they were doing to come here and help, but whenever she focuses on it, Melog turns their eyes at her and meows happily to communicate that they are perfectly fine with it. It's strange, and as it goes on for a few minutes, the situation feels more and more like that kids game in which you are allowed to move only when you aren't looked at. Except it's not movements but thoughts, any negative ones are forbidden, and Melog is clearly winning and simply waiting for her to give up.

Catra glances sideways at Adora who doesn't seem comfortable with the situation any more than before, yet the princess is looking far less anxious now. The feline girl wonders if she should be angry or jealous about it but she mostly feels relief. As expected, Catra finds it far less irritating when Adora looks uncomfortable rather than worried. She looks at Swift Wind and the unicorn only nods slowly as to confirm that the present silence is for her, intended as she wished. He has a lot more work than Melog to keep Adora quiet and in place though.

With almost no sound in the room, a long time passes. Catra is thinking too much about everything to really enjoy it but it's peaceful, and she can see that Adora is thinking just as much but is slowly, very slowly, relaxing and accepting the silence as something not so frightening. In the last five minutes, Swift Wind only had to remind her twice to keep her mouth shut. 'It's

progress!' Catra sarcastically chuckles and she's scolded by Melog in turn.

That's right, they have friends now. As much as Catra wants to think that she isn't at fault for the current issue, it's still an issue, and instead of stubbornly hoping for Adora to change her attitude, she could have asked. Melog? Sparkles? Maybe even Bow or Netossa, with whom she unexpectedly seems to get along well.

Catra looks at Adora who is almost smiling now. There is still some uneasiness on her face, and lots of questions, but nothing awful like before. Catra starts to think about the past again, about all those nights that they spent quietly alone. Actually, Adora was rarely completely silent; she just didn't talk about anything heavy and that was the important part. They don't *have to* be alone anymore though, but Catra would like to get that feeling back, and maybe she can; everything seems possible in this peaceful moment and she can feel herself smiling.

'Good.' Melog tells Catra directly as they stand up. They nuzzle her head for a little time, then gives Adora a lick on her face, and walks to the balcony. Swift Wind follows their lead, hugging the two girls in his wings shortly before getting out.

"Now what?" Catra asks hesitantly as she jumps after Melog.

'Now you two talk.'

The feline girl growls and frowns. "Talk?"

'Yes. You compromise. *She* needs it.' Melog adds as they glance at Adora.

Catra grunts and the alien cat bumps their head gently against her chest in a comforting manner. Melog purrs and produces a soothing happy meow before walking away again. While Swift Wind flies down to the garden, they jump from balconies to window stills until they get on the ground too. Both of them turn around once more to shout "good night" to the two girls who wave at them from the balcony, and off they go through the night.

Catra leans on the stone railing and looks into the distance, where their friends just disappeared into the darkness. After exhaling deeply in surrender, she glances at Adora. “You wanna talk?”

“If you want to.” Adora answers politely but they both know that she really wants to.

“Fine. You get one topic.”

“Is it comfortable? The way you nap.” says Adora without hesitation. She’s almost surprised herself how the words came out while she believed she was still pondering what to ask first.

“I’m not sure how to answer that? It’s a habit? Instinct maybe?”

“You don’t feel forced or that you have to act like a pet or… something? … stars it feels dumb when I say it aloud!”

“It just feels… normal I guess? What’s bothering you?”

“You don’t have to act like a cat anymore, okay?”

“But… I am like this? I didn’t choose?” Catra takes a deep breath. Thankfully Adora has said a few times that she loves her, all of her, and the feline girl believes it. “If you have a problem with a way I behave in particular, you better tell me straight because it’s beginning to be insulting of you to ask me to not act like *me*!”

“No! No, I mean, you don’t have to- Let me try again…” Adora breathes slowly twice. “Shadow Weaver treated you like a pet. I know I did too, even if I didn’t think that I did, even if I didn’t mean to… So if you are doing that because she forced it into you-”

“Adora. She made me a lot of things, but *obedient* isn’t one of them! I won’t *act like a pet* even if she was still here to order me to! It’s okay to see parts of me as cat-like, I guess. It’s just how I am. Why does this bother you so much?”

"I'm… not treating you like her anymore, right? I'm not making you feel like you are inferior, or just a wild animal?"

"Humans are animals, princess. And *you* are definitely in the *wild* category with me, with your reckless She-Ra!" Catra pauses for an instant and looks insistently at Adora. "You really think that if you didn't respect me I wouldn't let you know?"

"After all that happened?! That's… You're the one often telling that you don't deserve all this! If there's no problem why are you panicking every time I wake you up from that cat-like posture?"

Catra sighs. "Just… Prime's stuff. Don't worry about it."

"Prime's- How am I supposed to not worry about it?!"

"Because I ask you not to?"

"Catra, we can work this out. Talk to me! Help me help you-"

"There's nothing to do, now please, enough talk about this!" Catra puts a finger on Adora's lips to prevent her to answer any further. It doesn't work that easily; Adora struggles out of it as if the finger *does* actually stop her from speaking, and Catra has to pin her down on the bed to keep her hand on the princess' mouth. "You are enough! I don't need more."

"Why are you shutting me out like this?!" The princess shouts through Catra's hand and she averts her eyes in despair.

"I'm not shutting you *out*, I'm shutting you *up*! I said we don't need to talk about it! Why can't you just accept it and… stay with me… act like when we were kids…" Catra's last words are muffled since she didn't mean to say them, and Adora isn't sure she heard them right therefore doesn't answer immediately.

As often these days, their evening is interrupted by a few knocks on the door. Although like earlier, the door flies open and Glimmer enters as if she owns the place before they can answer. Catra's fur briefly stands on end at the queen's impudence. 'Well, technically,

she *does* own the place.' reasons Catra to stay calm. She doesn't bother to get down from Adora and she still has her hand silencing the blonde girl under her, who isn't sure how to react either.

Glimmer sighs and shrugs. "I won't ask… But you are missing dinner."

A few memories of a long gone past strike Adora like lightning and connect with Catra's last statement. '*missing dinner*', she had done that often with Catra as kids, when the feline girl had run away because she was hurt or sad. Adora never let her be alone, of course, for the better or worse. And being now older, it's easier to see the bad side of her persistence, but also the good one that kept Catra going all that time.

However, back then, the blonde girl wasn't acting or talking in a special way or anything, she was just there. She might have been annoyingly stubborn with it, but she never forced Catra to explain anything. The feline girl never asked for more, and Adora thought that it was because kitten Catra didn't dare, but she realises in her present situation that maybe, maybe the feline girl simply didn't *need* more. In those moment Catra had Adora all to herself and that was plenty.

"It's okay, Glimmer. Not now. We've got… things to work out first." Adora answers Glimmer but she keeps her eyes on Catra.

"Fine. I'm leaving you to... whatever you are doing. But you know the rules, don't come beg for dinner *later*."

Adora confirms with a strong "I know." and the queen leaves after giving the two girls a last insistent look that Catra returns with a frown.

The blonde girl grabs the opportunity that her girlfriend is distracted to straighten up and sits beside her instead of lying under. She takes Catra's hand in hers and leans so their shoulders touch. The feline girl is taken by surprise by Adora's suddenly soft

and sweet behaviour and when Catra glances at her face, there's no trace left of her previous concern.

"I'm sorry I forgot… It feels like last time was so long ago. *Not talking* took us on the wrong path, but you are right, maybe not everything needs to be talked about."

"Okay… shut up." Catra's words are sweet despite their meaning and her tail loops around Adora's waist to pull the blonde girl closer.

For a little time the room is kept silent once more. Catra finally feels calm and at ease, but Adora now looks jittery; there's definitely at least one question that the princess really wants to ask. She can't stop her free hand from moving on her knees, sometimes in a fist, then suddenly opening it, awkwardly looking at it as if she is afraid that she's sweating, grabbing the bed cover to have something to hold… Finally, Adora resolves herself to ask.

"Can I hug you?"

"If it helps you relax." The feline girl sighs.

Adora spins on herself to embrace Catra lightly from the side and holds the feline girl's head against her chest. The room returns to its silence for another short time, until the sound of a soft purr can be heard. Adora tenses up. There is so much she wants to speak about, so many gaps to fill from those last three years, and at least as many from their life before. If the princess understands correctly, it's not *talking* that bothers Catra but her choice of topic, and that lovely purr pushes Adora to want to conclude the previous one.

"Is it really okay? To pay attention to your cat-like traits, I mean."

"Yeah? Just think of it as paying attention *to me*?"

"And you don't mind being compared to a cat?"

“I spent some time with Netossa’s. It’s okay, they’re fun, strong, and cute- Don’t tell Bow I said that! Better yet, keep him away from me when he’s all *aahh, sooo cute!* or whatever.”

Adora giggles briefly and gives the feline girl’s ear a little rub. “Sooo… I can hug you and feel your fur whenever I want?”

“Mostly.” tempers Catra at Adora’s sudden burst of enthusiasm.

“Fluff your ears and tail?”

“When we are alone...”

“Tease you when you act all cutie-cat?” Adora begins to smirk mischievously.

“Please don’t.”

“Call you *my little kitten* when-”

“Definitely not!”

“Can I-”

Adora is interrupted by a loud growl from her stomach. She chuckles awkwardly after another instant of silence, and Catra wholeheartedly starts to laugh.

“We did miss dinner…” The princess justifies herself.

“Yeah, let’s go find some!” says Catra as she jumps up and holds out a hand to pull the blonde girl on her feet too.

“The kitchen is closed though.”

“Not like the supplies’ rooms are locked or anything… See? That’s when I need you to *worry and act for my sake*, princess!”

“Just so you know, I’ve... not…” Adora looks away in shame.

“What?”

“I... never…” She hesitates again.

“Adora?” Catra sighs again and some concern creeps up into her mind. She cups Adora’s face with both hands and softly pulls it back her way to look tenderly into the blonde girl’s eyes. “Please tell me?”

“I’ve never cooked for someone else... Have you?”

Catra’s worries disappear and she grins again; Adora will have to pay for that waste of her concern with food. “No way I’m getting my fur anywhere close to a stove! Do your best, princess! I’m counting on you!”

“Fine, I’ll do it! Can’t be that terrible if *I* like it myself! Right...

Catra… ehrm… Can I count.. *cutting raw vegetables in a salad* as *cooking*?”

“That I can do myself, so no.”

“… just for tonight?

… Please?”

End Notes

Thanks for reading! All my She-Ra works are part of the same big story, check my main series's description for more informations!

Please do share your thoughts! Comments are always welcome! Kudos too!
You can also find me on Discord to discuss, make suggestions or simply be notified when I post a new chapter!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!